

# Writing Workshop 101

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# MAGAZINE EDITING

How to Acquire  
the Skills You Need  
to Win a Job and Succeed  
in the Magazine Business

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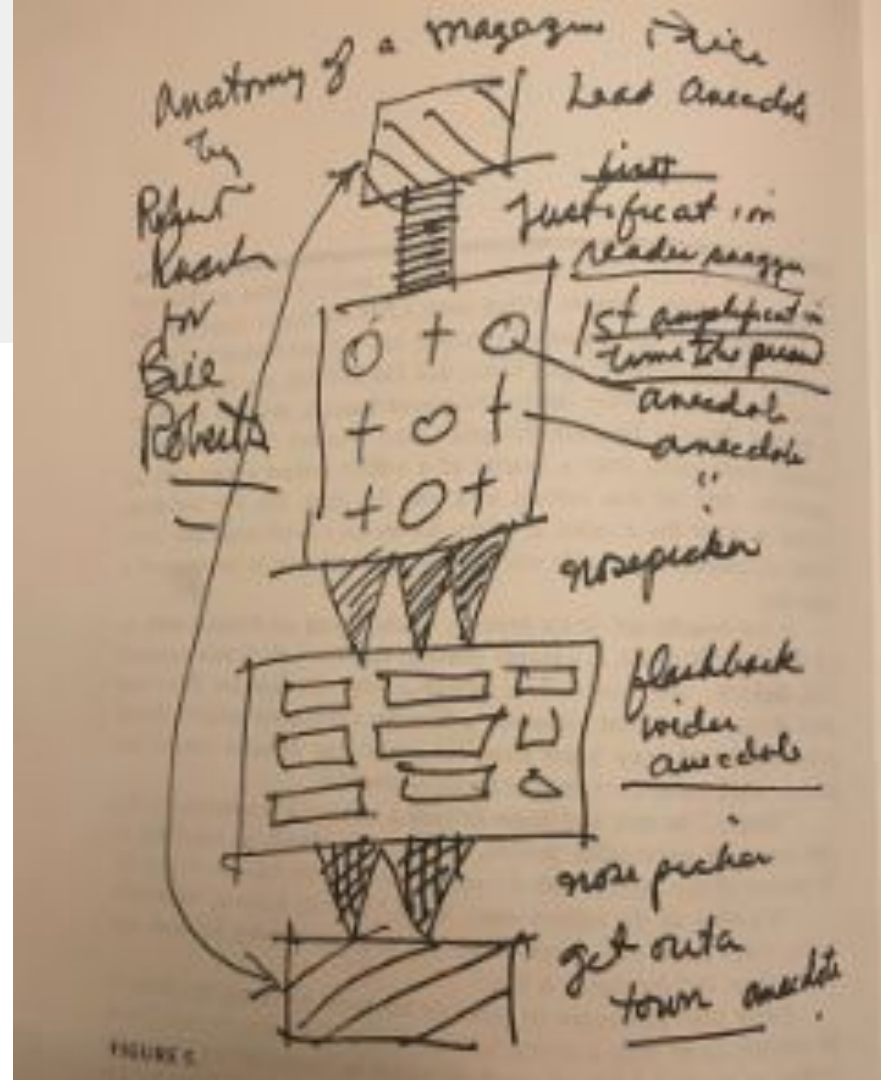
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# The Anatomy of a Profile



## SENATOR ON THE RUN

by Irwin Ross

Tenacious, tireless—and decidedly visible—Wisconsin's Bill Proxmire has been the consumer-taxpayer's friend for 21 years. His somewhat eccentric life-style only highlights the man's effectiveness

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One freezing morning last December, Sen. William Proxmire of Wisconsin joined a New York City sanitation crew and spent half a day wrestling garbage cans along a route in Brooklyn. What impelled the 62-year-old Senator to undertake such a chore? Very simple, says Proxmire. As chairman of the Senate banking committee, he had oversight responsibilities for New York's federal loan program and was thus interested in the efficiency of the city's operations. There was no better way to study sanitation than to join a garbage crew.

The New Yorkers worked hard, he decided. But the system in Fond du Lac, Wis., where he had also slung garbage, was significantly better.

The incident typifies Proxmire's offbeat approach to his job. He is a legendary eccentric and a superb self-promoter. A picture of him hoisting a garbage can was flashed across the country. So was the account, a few years ago, of how the balding Proxmire was sprouting hair after getting the first hair transplant in the history of the U.S. Senate.

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Far more than an oddball, Proxmire is an effective legislator who has scored significant victories in a ceaseless crusade against waste in government. Consumers can thank him for the 1968 truth-in-lending law, which enables the customer to determine at a glance the true cost of money he is borrowing, and the Fair-Credit Reporting Act of 1970, which makes accessible to individuals hitherto-secret information in their credit files.

A member of the Senate for 21 years, Proxmire has long enjoyed a love affair with

Wisconsin's voters. Two years ago he was re-elected with 73 percent of the vote, even though he raised no campaign funds. (His total reportable expenditures came to \$177.73, which he paid himself.) Probably the state's best-known politician, Proxmire had no trouble getting media coverage, and no anxiety about sharing it: he debated his Republican opponent 13 times. Every voter has either met him or knows someone who has. He calculates that each year he shakes hands with 150,000 Wisconsin citizens: some three

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million Senatorial handshakes over the years, in a state of 4.7 million people.

Proxmire has the courage to stand alone—indeed, at times seems to revel in it. He is difficult to label politically. Conservatives admire his emphasis on fiscal responsibility, liberals and laborites respect his generally liberal voting record. In addition, he has an understanding of the concerns of the business community. Thus he has long favored the investment tax credit, as well as a far more drastic proposal: a phased abolition of the corporate income tax, which he regards as a disincentive.

Affable Workaholic. The Proxmire life-style is equally remarkable. He is an ascetic, a physical-fitness enthusiast, a workaholic of awesome dimensions. He neither smokes nor drinks stimulants, scorning coffee and tea as well as alcohol, and he begins his day at 6 a.m. with a series of strenuous exercises, including 100 push-ups. If the Senate is in session, he runs—rain or shine—the 4.7 miles from his house in the Cleveland Park section of Washington to the Dirksen Senate Office Building. After showering, he changes to office clothes and prepares his own breakfast: fruit juice, a can of tuna or sardines, sprouted-wheat or sprouted-rye bread, and a

concoction he calls "tiger milk"—skim milk with wheat germ.

His day is rigidly structured: committee meetings in the morning, lunch at his desk, appointments with visitors after 3 p.m., a late-afternoon staff briefing for the next day's afternoon staff briefing for the next day's hearings.

He consumes memoranda as voraciously as a paper-shredder, speed-reading 1000 to 1500 words a minute. Several times a day he drops everything to answer a roll call. Proxmire has not missed a roll call in 11 years; his total is approaching 6000. No Senator has a better record.

For 11 years as well, Proxmire has made a speech to the Senate almost every day it has

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been in session, urging it to ratify the U.N. convention against genocide. So far, he has made such a speech about 2500 times. Often there are only a couple of other Senators in the chamber, plus the presiding officer. "But we are making progress," Proxmire insists. His tally now shows about 55 supporters.

The doggedness, the asceticism, the compulsive record-keeping, all suggest a dour, censorious personality. Not so. With a visitor, Proxmire's manner is relaxed, easygoing. There is no zealot's gleam in his eye, no bristling ego that impedes straight-forward conversation. He is a handsome six-footer with a firm chin line. The new hair, adequate in volume though hardly abundant, is carefully coiffed. He looks a decade younger than his 62 years.

From his youth Proxmire has been engaged in a ceaseless quest for self-improvement. When he was 12 he resolved for his complexion's sake to give up candy and sodas for a year—and also movies. Why movies? "I wanted to see if I could do it." He did.

Free-Swinging Crusader. No Senator can top him in dramatizing an issue. He often produces headlines when he issues his monthly Golden Fleece Award for the "biggest, most ridiculous or most ironic example of award, in March 1975, went to the National Science Foundation "for squandering \$84,000 to try to find out why people fall in love." Said Proxmire: "Not even the National Science Foundation can argue that falling in love is a science."

Later awards went to the Federal Aviation

Administration for a \$57,800 study of the body measurements of airline-stewardess trainees; to the Department of Agriculture for a \$46,000 investigation of the length of time it takes to cook breakfast; and to the U.S. Senate for planning to spend \$122 million on a third Senate office building. But sometimes his rhetoric gets out of hand, as when he

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spoke scornfully of "mink-swathed" Americans abroad seeking to preserve certain income-tax breaks they had long enjoyed. Many "cloth-swathed" Americans stationed overseas, hard hit both by inflation and by the declining dollar, scored him for a low blow.

In his crusade against government waste, Proxmire's greatest victory came in his campaign against subsidizing the supersonic transport. As far back as 1963, he argued that if the plane made economic sense, the private sector would back it. His first proposal to end support for the plane picked up only 6 votes against 72. But Proxmire is nothing if not tenacious; he made renewed efforts to end the project in 1966, '67 and '69.

The following year, the environmentalists entered the battle. Proxmire made common cause with them and, in December 1970, his amendment to strike SST funds won by a surprising 52 votes to 41. The maverick Proxmire was now recognized as a power in the Senate.

"Biggest Grind." Bill Proxmire was born on November 11, 1915, the second son of a hard-working doctor in Lake Forest, Ill. He was christened Edward, but at age five, after seeing cowbody-actor William S. Hart in a film, announced, "My name is Bill." He was so insistent that his parents gave way and he was enrolled in school as William.

There was great competition between Bill and his older brother, Ted, an outgoing youngster with many friends. At prep school, unable to rival Ted in personal popularity, Bill vowed to excel in studies. He became a straight-A student, and on graduation was voted the "biggest grind" as well as best dancer.

After Yale (class of '38) and the Harvard Business School, he got a job as a trainee at the J. P. Morgan bank in New York, leaving to serve in the Army. The war over, he married Elsie Rockefeller, a great-grandniece

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of John D. Then he enrolled at Harvard again to study government and economics.

In 1949 he methodically set about finding a community in which to pursue a career in journalism or politics. He made a list of every newspaper in the Middle West and in Washington and Oregon, with a circulation between 25,000 and 75,000, and applied to each for a job. And so at age 33 he became a \$40-a-week reporter on the *Capitol Times*, a crusading newspaper in Madison, Wis.

Fired after disagreements with the editor, he went to work for the weekly *Union Labor News*, and later started a radio program, "Labor Sounds Off." Then he decided to run for the state assembly, and amazed everyone by winning.

At Factory Gates. In the assembly he made a name for himself, specializing in fiscal matters, delivering carefully prepared speeches. In the 1952 gubernatorial election—when the Democrats had no obvious candidate—Proxmire, wanting the "exposure," stepped forward. He lost by 400,000 votes. But he ran closer races in '54 and '56. Meanwhile, divorced by his first wife, he married Ellen Hodges Sawall, executive secretary of the Wisconsin Democratic Party.

In his three gubernatorial races, Proxmire perfected the campaign style he has followed to this day. Its essence is personal contact—handshaking tours at factory gates starting at 6 a.m., at supermarkets in the afternoon, at football games on weekends. In his early campaigns he covered every ham-

let in the state, eating in diners, sleeping in \$2 hotel rooms to save money. On one occasion, unable to find a room in town, he spent the night stretched out in a barber's chair.

In 1954 he began his practice of appearing at plant gates the morning *after* the election, to thank voters for their support—the same cheerful Bill Proxmire, now the good loser. The voters were impressed.

When Sen. Joseph McCarthy died in 1957,

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a special Senatorial election was called. Proxmire—by this time Mr. Democrat—easily won his party primary, and then scored a substantial victory over the popular former governor, Walter J. Kohler.

In February 1959, a mere 18 months after being welcomed in Washington by the Democratic leadership, Proxmire attacked Lyndon Johnson's domination of the Senate in three lengthy speeches. He launched his assault on George Washington's Birthday. "The Senate today heard two speeches," one-colleague quipped: "Washington's farewell address, and the farewell address of Bill Proxmire."

The obituary was premature. Not only has Proxmire survived; he has become a powerful committee chairman, one of the Senate's movers and shakers. Yet he keeps running, tirelessly, working out his tensions in a series of rituals that have defined a personal life-style. It is a style few of his fellow legislators would care to emulate, but it has made him a legend in his time—and a national asset, as well.

# Fitzy's Top 10 Tips

1. **Panic early:** Your writing will improve exponentially based on how much time you give yourself to do it: If you Red Bull it at 4 a.m. it will be terrible and no one will want to read it, least of all your teacher or professor.
2. **Rewriting is the essence of writing:** You wrote 500 words and the assignment is 500 words. That does not mean you are done.
3. **Writing is hard work.** A clear sentence is no accident.
4. From William Zinsser, author of "On Writing Well," an essential book for any writer: "Our national tendency is to inflate and thereby sound important. The airline pilot who announced that he is presently anticipating experiencing considerable precipitation wouldn't dream of saying that it may rain. The sentence is too simple. There must be something wrong with it. But the core of good writing is to **strip every sentence to its cleanest components**. Every word that serves no function, every long word that could be a short word, every adverb that carries the same meaning that's already in the verb, every passive construction that leaves the reader unsure of who is doing what -- these are the thousand and one adulterants that weaken the strength of a sentence. And they usually occur, ironically, in proportion to education and rank." (Nowhere is that more true than at universities) "At this point in time" = "now"

# Fitzzy's Top 10 Tips

5. **The most important sentence in any article is the first one.**

(The second most important is the last one, the kicker).

6. The lead is usually **what you would tell your mother** if she asked what the story is.

7. **Most adverbs are unnecessary.**

8. **Use active verbs:** "Joe hit him" is strong. "He was hit by Joe" is weak.

9. **Read, read, read. Write, write, write.**

10. **Fear** and **coffee.**

# Questions?

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